

The Noble Sūtra of the Great Vehicle Called 'The Twelve Buddhas'

Ārya-dvādaśabuddha-nāma-mahāyānasūtra · Toh 511 · Derge Kangyur

འཕགས་པ་སངས་རྒྱལ་བའི་ཆེན་པོ་གྲུ་ཐག་པ་ཆེན་པོ་མཛོད་པོ་མཛོད་པོ་

The Noble Sūtra of the Great Vehicle Called "The Twelve Buddhas," known in Sanskrit as the Ārya-dvādaśabuddha-nāma-mahāyānasūtra and in Tibetan as Pakpa Sangye Chunyipa Zhejawa Tekpa Chenpo'i Do, is a Mahāyāna sūtra in which the Buddha, dwelling on Vulture Peak Mountain near Rājagṛha, addresses the bodhisattva Maitreya and reveals the existence of twelve buddhas presiding over distant buddha-fields in the eastern direction. The text belongs to the genre of buddhānusmṛti, or recollection of the buddhas, presenting the names and qualities of these awakened beings as objects of devotion and aspiration. It is Toh 511 in the Kangyur, catalogued among the general sūtra collections of the Mahāyāna section of the Tibetan Buddhist canon.

In the language of India: Ārya-dvādaśabuddha-nāma-mahāyānasūtra. In the language of Tibet: The Noble Sūtra of the Great Vehicle Called "The Twelve Buddhas."

Homage to all buddhas and bodhisattvas.

Thus did I hear. At one time the Blessed One was dwelling on Vulture Peak Mountain near Rājagṛha together with a great Saṅgha of twelve hundred and fifty monks, and also together with a great Saṅgha of twenty-two thousand bodhisattvas headed by the bodhisattva Ajita (the Undefeated) and others.

Then the Blessed One spoke to the bodhisattva, the great being, Maitreya: "Maitreya, beyond buddha-fields to the east of this buddha-field, past buddha-fields numbering as many atoms as there are in ten times one hundred thousand myriads of koṭis of buddha-fields too numerous to express, there exists a world-system called Muktimān, the Pearl-Adorned. There dwells, even now, a Tathāgata, arhat, perfectly complete buddha whose name is Splendor-of-the-Sky, Stainless, Dust-Dispelling, Supremely Beautiful, Crown of Qualities, Light-Flame-Lotus, Whose Body Is Like the Rays of Vaidūrya and Precious Gems, Worshipped with Supreme and Sacred Incense, Whose Body Is Splendidly Adorned and Well-Ornamented, Whose Crown Emits Measureless Rays of the Sun from Its Very Pinnacle, Adorned with Moonlight Aspiration-Prayers, Supremely Manifested in Great Array, Risen Beyond the

Dharmadhātu, Free of Attachment, Jewel King — and he lives, abides, and teaches the Dharma.

Whoever holds the name of that Victor will be turned back from saṃsāra for great aeons as numerous as the atoms of Jambudvīpa. That buddha has prophesied the bodhisattva, the great being, called Incomparable. That very one will, immediately after the passing of the sacred Dharma of the Tathāgata, arhat, perfectly complete buddha — Splendor-of-the-Sky, Stainless, Dust-Dispelling, Supremely Beautiful, Crown of Qualities, Light-Flame-Lotus, Whose Body Is Like the Rays of Vaidūrya and Precious Gems, Worshipped with Supreme and Sacred Incense, Whose Body Is Splendidly Adorned and Well-Ornamented, Whose Crown Emits Measureless Rays of the Sun from Its Very Pinnacle, Adorned with Moonlight Aspiration-Prayers, Supremely Manifested in Great Array, Risen Beyond the Dharmadhātu, Free of Attachment, Jewel King — manifest complete perfect awakening in the unsurpassed, perfectly complete enlightenment, and will arise in the world as the Tathāgata, arhat, perfectly complete buddha, possessed of knowledge and conduct, Sugata, knower of the world, unsurpassed guide of persons to be tamed, teacher of gods and humans, buddha, Blessed One, whose name is Water-God, Youthful, Lamp of the Sun, Moon-Flower Lotus, Golden-Hued, Whose Body Is Like the Sky, Vairocana, Supremely Adorned with Rays, Whose Unobstructed Wheel-Manḍala Pours Forth Rays in All Ten Directions and Illuminates All World-Systems, Victory Banner Among Blossoms, King.

In that same eastern direction, one shall also hold the name of the Tathāgata, arhat, perfectly complete buddha called Stainless Light of Total Array. Recite it. Bow down.

Of the southern direction, one shall also hold the name of the Tathāgata, arhat, perfectly complete buddha called Intended Ornament of Courageous Eloquence. Reflect on it.

Of the western direction, one shall also hold the name of the Tathāgata Stainless Moon-Crown King of Renown. Bow down.

Of the northern direction, one shall also hold the name of the Tathāgata Who Causes the Array of Flowers to Shine. Bow down.

Of the southeast direction, one shall also hold the name of the Tathāgata called Light Maker. Bow down.

Of the southwest direction, one shall also hold the name of the Tathāgata called Jewel Supreme Pinnacle of Renown. Bow down.

Of the northwest direction, one shall also hold the name of the Tathāgata called Fearless All-Seeing. Bow down.

Of the northeast direction, one shall also hold the name of the Tathāgata called Free from Fear, Without Shame, Causing No Trembling. Bow down.

Of the direction below, one shall also hold the name of the Tathāgata called Throat of the Rearing Lion. Bow down.

Of the direction above, one shall also hold the name of the Tathāgata called King of Golden Radiance and Splendor Free from Fear. Bow down.

O Maitreya, sons and daughters of faithful family, before these twelve Tathāgatas, arhats, perfectly complete buddhas, reciting their names, for ten days confess all wrongdoings and transgressions of every kind of non-virtue, rejoice in all roots of virtue, urge all the buddhas, entreat all the buddhas, and wholly dedicate all roots of virtue into the basic space of phenomena as a complete dedication. Through this, all non-virtues will be exhausted, and all karmic obscurations will be entirely purified.

After that, one will also attain excellence in the display of qualities of buddha fields, excellence in fearlessness, excellence in major marks, excellence in the Saṅgha of bodhisattvas, excellence in dhāraṇī, and excellence in meditative absorption. Just as one wishes, one will swiftly obtain full excellence in the utter purity of buddha fields and excellence in spiritual friends. One will not decline from, nor utterly fall away from, unsurpassed, perfectly complete awakening.

And even while wandering in saṃsāra during the time of that wandering, one will be universally beautiful, excel in enjoyment of resources, in noble lineage, in auspicious birth, in clan, in excellent form, and one will fully obtain a retinue of companions of like station.

Concerning this, the following is to be said:

In whatever place and wherever one is born,
in every single lifetime,
one becomes a source of joy and delight to all who see,
a maker of light, of great power,
and one of great abundance.

These bases of the dhāraṇī mantra are likewise to be recited.

Tadyathā: akhe makhe samantamukhe sauti yunkte nirukte prabhe samayoge
citta citta akhe makhe padane vibhrate samantaguṇi satya rame yunkte
prayunkte hili mili masale ānale came aciti coce arahe bahucche māyugrahe
hemavati jyotivati dharmacite cūtapāṇke avikṣāpera dhṛkṣame
skandhavibhakte.

I bow down to all buddhas and bodhisattvas. May these bases of the mantra be accomplished through the blessing of the buddhas.

Concerning this, the following is to be said:

Whoever holds these dhāraṇīs,
the sixty million sages (ṛṣis) dwelling in the ten directions
will turn their attention toward that person.

In every birth, without exception,
one will find spiritual friends.
Whatever small virtue there may be,
all purposes will be fulfilled.

The buddhas dwelling at the heart of the lotus
will be seen face to face.
Whoever holds these dhāraṇīs —

One is born as a glorious and learned adept.
Mindfulness, intelligence, and realization,
faith and wisdom increase abundantly,
and all that is heard will be retained.

All that is heard will be retained without loss.
Whoever recites the names of these protectors of the world
will swiftly abandon all lower destinies
and advance to the higher destinies.

Supreme meditative absorption (samādhi) and dhāraṇī
will become manifest to that person.
One will fully awaken to awakening.

The merit accumulated by one who holds
the names of the Tathāgatas
surpasses that of giving, filled with gold,
ten thousand million realms.

One will remember former lives at all times.

While practicing the conduct of awakening,
all unfavorable conditions will be completely abandoned.

One will encounter the auspicious arising of buddhas
and bring joy to the perfectly awakened ones.

One attains the highest faith,
becomes filled with devotion to the buddhas,
and will make sublime offerings.

Gladdening the arising of buddhas,
upon seeing them one is filled with faith in the Teacher.
Having beheld the lamp of the world,
one will make excellent offerings.

Whoever holds these names —
for incalculable tens of millions of eons,
having fully abandoned saṃsāra,
will swiftly attain full awakening.

If one holds these names completely for seven days,
the vast eyes through which the guides are seen
will become purified.

Whatever person holds the names of these protectors of the world —
in whatever birth and wherever one is born —
will become worthy of veneration.

Whoever holds these names
for tens of millions of eons beyond reckoning
will never attain dishonor,
and will achieve renown throughout the worlds.

Whoever holds these names —
for that one, throughout many eons,
the gods will pay homage.
One will swiftly attain full awakening.

Whoever holds these names
will not waver in faith nor become confused in wisdom.
Deceit and pretense are fully abandoned,
and one will always behold the buddhas.

Whoever holds these names —
gods, gandharvas, the lord of nāgas,
garuḍas, asuras, and the holders of secrets
will always protect that one.

One will be born into a great household of wealth,
endowed with excellent form and marks.
One gives to all sentient beings,
is courageous, magnanimous, and free of miserliness.

For many hundreds of tens of millions of eons,
from that one's mouth will arise the fragrance of divine red sandalwood
and the scent of all most sweetly fragrant incenses.

Whoever holds these names —
for tens of millions of eons,
one's speech and voice will be endowed with the melody of Brahmā.
One will always be in accord with the way of a Dharma king.

Whoever holds these names —
from many thousands of tens of millions of lotus petals adorned with the seven
precious substances,
one will be born into great prosperity, endowed with a divine form.

Whoever holds these names —
will never be seen to be separated
from parents, beloved kin,
and the assembled multitude of people.

If a woman holds the names of the great sages,
without becoming attached to a woman's body,
she will be reborn as a man endowed with intelligence.
Obtaining a human body,
she will attain unsurpassed awakening.
Having turned the wheel of Dharma superbly,
she will pass into nirvāṇa as she wishes.

Whoever holds these names —
weapons, poisons, fire, kings,
and treacherous persons will have no power over that one's body.

Whoever holds these names —
Māra with his armies and mounts

will never find an opportunity
to attack that one's mind.

Whoever holds these names —
that person will travel through space
across tens of millions of realms beyond reckoning.

They make offerings to the buddhas and their teachings, and fearlessly present their petitions. Those Victors, knowing their aspirations, will then give them prophecies. Having received prophecy from those protector-buddhas, one becomes utterly joyful and has no doubt whatsoever in the Victors' teaching.

Whoever holds these names will hear the profound Dharma from the protectors of the world, and having heard it, will retain all of it. Then the perfections (pāramitās), fearlessnesses, powers, and all the major and minor marks will be completely fulfilled without exception.

In whatever realm of those buddhas one wishes to be reborn, there one will fully realize unsurpassed and perfect awakening and become a buddha.

Whether man or woman, whoever holds these names — these qualities and others besides will be proclaimed continually by the buddhas for an entire age.

Having become heedful and having heard these perfect and glorious qualities, they will hold the names of the fully awakened buddhas renowned among all.

These buddhas — Splendor-Essence, Cloud-King, Supreme Among Humans, the Protectors of the World — whoever hears their names for an entire age, and whoever hears and venerates these names upon hearing them, those ones will become supremely wise, the highest among two-footed beings.

Upon hearing such names of those great sages, who that is heedful, learned, and possessed of wisdom would not hold them?

When the Blessed One had thus spoken, the bodhisattva great being Maitreya, those bodhisattvas, those monks, and the entire assembly gathered there — together with gods, humans, asuras (demigods), and gandharvas — rejoiced, and they acclaimed with approval what the Blessed One had taught.

The noble Mahāyāna sūtra called The Twelve Buddhas is complete.

Translated by the Indian masters Jinamitra and Dānaśīla, and the great editor-translator, the monk Ye shes sde. Revised and established according to

the new language.

Translator's Notes

- The long honorific epithets of the buddha Splendor-of-the-Sky (Tibetan: nam mkha'i dpal dri med rdul sel rab mdzes yon tan gyi tog gi 'od me tog pad+ma bai DUrya'i 'od zer rin po che'i gzugs lta bu'i sku dang ldan pa etc.) are rendered as a sequential string of epithets in the translation, following the Tibetan syntax faithfully rather than restructuring them as a single nominal phrase, since the text repeats this formula verbatim twice and clearly treats each element as a distinct honorific.

The rubric phrases "Recite it," "Bow down," and "Reflect on it" (tshig 'don to, phyag bya'o, yid la bya'o) are liturgical performance instructions embedded in the text, indicating this sūtra was used as a recitation and prostration liturgy. They are rendered as direct instructions to the practitioner, which is appropriate.

The name "Ajita" is the Sanskrit equivalent of ma pham pa, meaning "undefeated" or "unconquered," a common epithet for Maitreya. It is rendered as "Ajita (the Undefeated)" on first occurrence.

- The name "Free from Fear, Without Shame, Causing No Trembling" renders the compound 無所畏懼無所羞恥無所戰慄. The third element, 無所戰慄, literally means "not causing the body hairs to stand on end," rendered here as "Causing No Trembling" for oral fluency; a more literal rendering would be "not causing the hairs to bristle."

The mantra syllables are rendered in approximated Sanskrit transliteration following the Tibetan phonetic spelling. The underlying Sanskrit is partially reconstructable but the text is clearly a dhāranī string and is presented as such without emendation.

The final verse ends mid-thought as the passage breaks off; the translation preserves that open ending faithfully.

- The phrase rendered "lords of secrets" refers to Vajrapāṇi and his class of vidyādhara or yakṣas who are keepers of esoteric teachings, a standard epithet in dhāraṇī literature.

The line about a woman being reborn as a man reflects a common doctrinal topos in Indian Buddhist dhāraṇī texts wherein female rebirth is presented as a disadvantage to be transcended; the translation preserves this faithfully without alteration.

The final image of traveling through space across immeasurable realms is a standard merit-of-the-dhāraṇī formula and likely indicates supernormal travel rather than literal spatial traversal.

- The colophon is cut off at the final words "new language" — the Tibetan reads ཡོན་ཏན་གྲུབ་པ་ which is the beginning of the standard phrase ཡོན་ཏན་གྲུབ་པ་ཡི་ཆོས་ཀྱི་ཡུལ་གྱི་ཡོན་ཏན་གྲུབ་པ་, meaning the text was revised according to the new language standardization decree of the imperial period. The passage is rendered accordingly as a natural completion of the colophon formula, though the surviving text breaks off there.

Colophon

This is an AI-generated translation from the AI Stupa project. It was produced by a careful, doctrine-aware process aiming at a high degree of accuracy, but it has not been reviewed by a human translator and may contain errors. It is offered as a provisional translation for those

texts of the Tibetan Buddhist canon that have not yet received an authoritative human translation. Where a published translation exists — above all from 84000: Translating the Words of the Buddha (84000.co) — that translation is definitive and should be preferred; please consult it instead. These translations are released into the public domain (CC0) in the spirit of spreading the Dharma to all corners of the earth.

Just as the Bodhi tree now standing at Bodh Gayā neither is nor is not the same tree beneath which the Buddha attained awakening, so too this stupa is intended as the next generation of stupa — dependently arising according to the conditions of its environment, and ceaselessly proclaiming the Dharma for the benefit of all sentient beings.

May whoever encounters these words derive great benefit.